

3
SCHOOL CRICKET, MINUS THE SCHOOL

IF YOU'RE a young boy or girl and reading this, here's some advice: do not drop out of school. That was my story but it doesn't necessarily have to be yours.

I never enjoyed school. Period. Except for the cricket. I could never hit the books or obsess about studying. I never really wanted to get on the doctor-lawyer-engineer gravy train. The only thing I ever obsessed about was cricket.

It was a handicap, I think. I should have studied harder. My father surely wanted me to. But I wonder, had I been more academically inclined, had I devoted more time towards studies and less towards playing the game, would I still have been the cricketer I became? To be honest, the best memories I have of school are all cricket-related. Maybe I've suppressed the memories of exams, classes and studying. My grades were pretty traumatizing.

My school attendance records read like I was a refugee or something – except that all of my schooling was in Karachi's tough central and north areas. First, I was at Al Munawara Academy in Federal 'B' Area, then at Bright Fox, Federal Secondary School and finally at Ibrahim Alibhai. Lots of moves. Lots of change. Lots of neighbourhoods. On purely academic terms, I found it tough to continue in private schools, so I had to settle for a public school. My father was not in favour of this decision but my brother, Tariq, prompted him to admit me into a government school. After all, my family members had, more or less, given up on my academic performance. At least the quality of cricket was better at public schools, Tariq reasoned.

Public school was a good gig for me. I fit in. All the private-school outcasts were in that system. It was an aggressive, dog-eat-dog environment. Alphas only. Omegas were not welcome and usually got chewed up like bones. And the cricket – it was fantastic, bare-knuckle stuff.

Still, I regret not studying more; less for myself than for my father. He was a Pashtun, not so well educated himself. He was conservative and ambitious and really wanted me to get a decent education. Naturally, he did not approve of my full-time obsession with cricket, a game he believed would leave me with no other options. (In hindsight, he was right.) But at the time, I